

Legislative DEATH ROW

The UPA Government sets a record of sorts as 68 bills face extinction in both the Houses

By Shafi Rahman |

If we moms can push nine-pound babies through our bodies, some of them with heads as big as bowling balls, surely we can push legislation through the halls of Congress," wrote Donna Dees Thomases, the New Jersey parent who triggered the Million Mom March that led to legislations restricting the private ownership of firearms in the US. The United Progressive Alliance (UPA) Government has the right to feel these words are not written for them. The 14th Lok Sabha is in its last phase and 68 bills introduced by the Manmohan Singh Government are facing their demise. The bills, ranging from political hot potatoes like the Women's Reservation Bill to ones that deal with drunken driving, are stuck in both Houses of Parliament and myriad parliamentary standing committees, creating a legislative logjam.

While only seven bills lapsed in the first Lok Sabha, that figure went up steadily to 39 during the term of the UPA. While these 39 bills will lapse by the end of the session, the fate of 29 bills, which were introduced in the Rajya Sabha but never made their way to the Lok Sabha, will be decided by the next Government. The fact that many of the bills have been travelling this maze since 2005 gives an idea of the urgency shown by the UPA in pushing its agenda. The bill to amend the Forward Contracts (Regulation) Act slated to be taken up during every session of Parliament since 2005 was never tabled till March 2008, days before the party congress of crucial ally CPI(M) which opposed a provision in the bill allowing trading of essential commodities in the futures market.

CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat fumed at the meet: "The problem with the Government is that when the right hand does something good, the left hand does something else." Later, the all powerful "Left hand" prevailed and the bill never made it to the Rajya Sabha. You could say that the Government couldn't act thanks to



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the protectionist, anti-reform reflexes of the Left. But the bills the Government pushed through to meet immediate political challenges and left in the lurch when tensions eased narrate the other side of the story.

In October 2007, on a day the Sensex touched 20,000 points, over 30,000 people marching on foot arrived in Delhi, seeking restoration of land to the dispossessed, indicating the ever-widening gulf between two Indias and vividly illustrated in violence in a number of states, including West Bengal. On December 6, 2007 the Government introduced the Rehabilitation and Resettlement Bill in the Lok Sabha to provide mechanisms to deal with displacement relief and rehabilitation. The bill became a bestseller among civil society groups from the nanosecond it was introduced but got stuck in the Lok Sabha and is on its way to the grave.

In some cases, bills were brought in to satisfy fancies